AWKWARD ECOLOGIES: THE 21ST CENTURY BAROQUE

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ABSTRACT

An examination of those forms of music that are genealogically related to musique concrète – identified variously as acousmatic music, electroacoustic music, and sound-based music – which makes the core argument that the mastery of sound matter, and by extension of nature, is now extensive enough that the modes of intention and reception underpinning these forms of music, are secondary to a particular mode: the technological. The talk unfolds this argument as a necessary preamble to my conclusion, which sketches a relationship between this argument and the notions of ecology and a 21st century baroque.

1. AWKWARD ECOLOGIES: THE 21ST CENTURY BAROQUE

My talk is part of a larger project that seeks to engage in an ecologically informed way with the practice of making sound-based music (Landy 2007) with technology. Clearly I am far from alone in doing this, as evidenced by many of topics being addressed at this conference and the recent EMS conference in New York, and the relatively recent rise in the arts and humanities of what is sometimes called ecocriticism, which has made its way into electroacoustic music studies via the most recent issue of *Organised Sound*.[1] What I think I am working towards is the replacement of the ethos of technocratic modernism – which underpinned musique concrète and perhaps still underpins electroacoustic music – with ways of thinking about and making music with technology that is appropriate to the large-scale challenges of our contemporary milieu, especially at an ecological level. Certainly this informs my own practice. Set within the specific context of this present conference, this might be defined as a re-auralising of the organic and our relationship to it. It is also predicated on a deliberately naïve approach, so as to enable me to get around the presuppositions that I'm most likely to bring to bear upon my listening and thinking.

Before launching the body of my subject, let me give some historical context by reprising the notional failure of musique concrète which is the background to my talk. This is summarized from an essay of mine recently published in *eContact!* (McKinnon 2011), and it should be pointed out that the gist of this argument is by no means entirely original (see Kahn 1999, and Harrison 2006).

Toward the end of his life, Pierre Schaeffer soundly dismissed musique concrète:

> Musique concrète in its work of assembling sound, produces sound-works, sound-structures, *but not music*... The whole problem of the sound-work is distancing oneself from the dramatic… Just as a painter or sculptor moves away from a model, stops representing a horse, or a wounded warrior, and arrives at the abstract… And *if you continue this abstracting movement… you get to music*. (Schaeffer and Hodgkinson 1987) [emphasis mine]

Schaeffer was at pains to find a means to eliminate the extrinsic from sound-based music as he – like his nemesis Pierre Boulez – maintained that the referential and semantic qualities of sound significantly diminished its formal, which is to say musical, potential. This he argued could only be developed at an intrinsic level, through the perception of similarities and differences in purely sonorous qualities which would "weaken the interest which could be taken in identifying objects which would otherwise present as a series of heterogenous events" (Schaeffer in Chion, 32)

This was spurred in part by Boulez's scathing critique of musique concrète in his short essay *Music (Concrete)* (1966), a title playing sardonically upon the meanings of the word concrete, but clearly favouring the noun:

> The word concrete reveals how [electroacoustic technology] was misled and the gross way in which the problem [of using this technology] was envisaged; it was aimed at defining a material manipulation of sonority, that sonority itself not responding to any definition or being subject to any restriction… That lack of directing thought resulted in total insolvency of the exploration… (290)

This effort to 'purify' sound was largely addressed through the practice of reduced listening [*ecouté reduite*], an aesthetic-cognitive practice derived by Schaeffer from the phenomenological reduction or bracketing [*epoché*] developed by Edmund Husserl. Reduced listening was conceived as the cognitive practice that would support Schaeffer's "Solfège of the Sonic Object [which] purports to take, from the practice of sound-producing bodies… a universal musicalness through a technique of hearing… [from this] new musics are expected to arise, based on reference structures that should play, for each of the seven morphological criteria, a role similar to that played by interval relations and the games of tonality and modality." (Palombini 1999).

[1] *Organised Sound*, 16(2)

Schaeffer's solfege was the core of his effort to establish a conceptual structure through which sound-based music could be understood to operate: reduced listening acting as the cognitive apparatus which maintains the solfege system as an agreed set of units within a hierarchically organised structure, such as already exists in instrumental music.

In short, Schaeffer sought a means to cleanse sound of its picaresque impurities so as to allow musique concrète to function in the same abstract and formal ways deemed essential by the Boulez and his fellow high modernists. It was this direction that Schaeffer followed, rather than embracing the vibrant heterogeneity of sound and the consequent problematisation or complexification of the notion of musical discourse. Concomitant with this theoretical endeavor to master sound was the drive towards the practical instrumentalisation of sound, a project integral to Schaeffer's leadership of the GRM: "Pierre Schaeffer would promote the construction of new machines that would simplify the operations on sound." (Terrugi 2007, 216). Machines such as the phonogène in various forms, the morphophone, and others, have played a key role in the development of electroacoustic technologies, as the ongoing popularity of GRM Tools attests. It is perhaps fair to say that electroacoustic technologies are now sufficiently advanced to be understood as musical instruments, through which virtuoso composers can largely master the sound world. As Boulez (2010) recently put it "With electronic media, one cannot only create new sounds and timbres, but one is free to fulfill all wishes, limited only by the imagination itself." The extent to which such a utopian vision is true is open to some debate, but it certainly points to the intentional will-to-power, manifest through technology, which is a strong aspect of the making of sound-based music, and also, a dominant aspect of its interpretation also. I'll get into this argument by looking at intentionality.

Philosopher of music Roger Scruton maintains that "The notes in [instrumental] music float free from their causes… What we understand, in understanding music, is not the material world, but the intentional object: the organisation that can be heard *in* the music" (Scruton in Hamilton, 2007). Needless to say the idea of music-as-intentionality is exactly what Schaeffer was trying to get at through the cognitive transformation of sound (reduced listening, the solfege) and its technological transformation also (see Schaeffer in Terrugi 2007, 215). In this, the concrete sonorous experience, the experience of sonic materiality, is to be set aside in favour of the abstract and the formal: we listen *past* sound, whether that of banal noises or rarefied instruments, to encounter music. As expressed in terms familiar to electroacoustic composers, "Musique concrète… starts from 'concrete' (i.e. observable) qualities in sound material itself, from which structural implications are extrapolated and links to other sound materials made. What finally emerges… is an 'abstract' musical discourse" (Harrison 2006, 4). Despite whatever differences there might be still be between instrumental and electroacoustic music, they are closely allied in this abstracting tendency, which derives from an ideology of transcendence in Western art music, which in turn is a more general and persistent mindset in Western cultures. Much more needs to be said about this, but in this context such my shorthand will have to suffice.

In both instrumental and electroacoustic music then, we listen through sound to arrive at music. But where does this leave Scruton's intentional object in regard to sound-based music? If we do not have an abstract system that somehow lies behind sound, as exists in note-based instrumental music, where do we arrive at apropos the "the organisation that can be heard *in* the music" that both Schaeffer and Boulez hold dear? If, following Harrison, in sound-based music the abstract emerges *out of* the observation of the concrete, and, following Smalley (1997, 14) "There is no permanent type of hierarchical organisation for all electroacoustic music, or even within a single work", then is there any intentional object to be found *beyond* sound in sound-based music? A response to this conundrum might follow three lines.

Firstly, following Schaefferian principles, there may well be music beyond sound, but it is most certainly not of the kind that Schaeffer hoped to find; that is, there is no structural equivalent in sound-based music to the structures of note-based music. Secondly, an answer obvious to electroacoustic composers: surely the intentional object of sound-based music is found in the qualities of sound itself, rather than in something which floats magically behind it? This is the logic and value of Smalley's spectromorphology project; intrinsic sonic qualities, extrinsic references, the threads between these, are concrete rather than abstract. Even here though, the principles of abstraction and formalisation remain in play. It is not that Smalley's taxononomy of texture, gesture, behavior and so forth cannot be discerned in sound-based music, but that these are *knowingly* discerned and this – like reduced listening – is a secondary level of awareness, a cognitive practice that has to be learned. Thirdly, is there a more immediate sense of the intentional object? The standard way to approach this follows Schaeffer's line: first we listen referentially, for sources and causes, before moving onto more symbolic modes of listening (semantic and reduced listening). I'd like to dwell a little longer in this initial causal level, because perhaps it is the case that the technologically mediated art of electroacoustic music doesn't necessarily lead us to the notional object dubbed the source-cause, even when what we hear is primarily phonographic, involving only an absolute minimum of technological intervention. Instead, it might be said that the most fundamental aspects of referential listening are on the one hand listening for *intentionality itself*, listening in the awareness that what we hear is intentional rather than accidental, and on the other hand, listening for clues as to how this intention is played out. In electroacoustics, this is analogous to saying of

instrumental music, "I'm listening to someone play the violin". There is a technology and someone using the technology. There is an interaction between someone and a something, or somethings, and one of those somethings is always a piece of technology. Perhaps this interaction is the most basic intentional object we can access, and technology is implicit in it. At one level this is an inane statement to make in the context of a computer music conference. But what I'm doing, following Heidegger rather than Husserl, is trying to draw awareness to something that is so close to us that we do not hear it anymore.

One significant consequence of such renewed awareness is that a primary aspect of referential listening is technology, or at least the interaction between an originating source-cause and a technological intervention with it that is a secondary source-cause. This is more or less to say that technological listening is unavoidable to some degree because it inheres in the electroacoustic experience itself. It is only the practiced listener who can detach sound from the electroacoustic apparatus, to hear it as sound rather than as technologically mediated sound, and this in itself might well be classed as an entry-level form of reduced listening. Were this *not* something that we all tend to do as technologist-artists then we might have witnessed the advent of an electroacoustic equivalent of *"Hörspielstreifen* [in film], the delicate atmosphere of recorded silence whose purpose is to imperceptibly confirm the presence of a reproduction underway and not frighten the audience into thinking there has been a technical malfunction (which would require a break in the silence of the audience itself)… (Kahn, 181).

Given all this, Smalley's concern for technological listening needs to be reframed somewhat. Smalley writes that "The composer, or other listeners conversant with technology and techniques, cannot easily brush aside a particular listening mode which I call technological listening. Technological listening occurs when a listener 'perceives' the technology or technique behind the music rather than the music itself, perhaps to such an extent that true musical meaning is blocked." (1997, 109) What I am suggesting is that technology *cannot* be brushed aside. This is because one important aspect of the intentional object of sound-based music is the listening for the technological manipulation and organization of sound. Intentionality is, at one level, a sonic concretion of technology; the intentional object emerges from the interaction of composer, technology, and sound. Where Smalley states that "Ideally the technology should be transparent, or at least the music needs to be composed in such a way that the qualities of its invention override any tendency to listen primarily in a technological manner" (109), I would rather say that the technology is never transparent and that what constitutes technological listening is instead an informed listener's awareness of the level of taste and skill with which technology has been deployed. For a naïve listener this is not the case and technological listening, as a mode of referential listening, tends to predominate, attaching itself along the way to whatever semantic reference points are suggested by technology, hence the reactions Andra McCartney (2002) encounters in her reader-response study "Alien Intimacies: Hearing science fiction narratives in Hildegard Westerkamp's *Cricket Voice*".

In terms of the ecological task of this talk, I am interested in the ways in which this version of technological listening alerts us to the fact that we are inside technology and that it changes, in some instances profoundly, the ways in which we hear and relate to the world through sound. There are many ways in which this idea might be developed but for now, given that time is pressing I would like, in closing, to offer one suggestion: that it offers a refigured understanding of our relationship with technology. Rather than approaching it as something other to ourselves, as tools that we somehow "just use", we must understand ourselves as part of an electroacoustic *assemblage* (see Deleuze and Guattari 1987, and Bennett 2010) comprising human and non-human, the latter both natural and artificial. This might be understood as an *awkward ecology*, not least of all given the modernist ethos of mastery that I mentioned earlier. As part of an assemblage, which is not an organic unity "in which the parts obediently serve the whole" (Bennett, 23), we both cede power to and draw power from other elements in the assemblage. Thus the composer is not detached from technology, or the soundfield, or the sound materials that yield so-called sound objects, but is intimately enmeshed in these. Not only this, but compositional outcomes are as much determined by the technology and the materials the composer is working with as they are by the composer. Sounds and technologies become primogenitors of music in collaboration with composers. Compositional consciousness is altered by the sounds and technologies it is engaged by and with. Our auralisation of the world is transformed by electroacoustic technologies, just as the visual technology of linear perspective transformed Western culture in the 16th century (see Romanyshyn 1989). This is baroque or grotesque, in that it challenges our sense of the proper order of things, and also in the sense that it is suggests a thing "roughly thrown together", in Jane Bennett's words an "ad hoc groupings of diverse elements… living, throbbing confederations that are able to function despite the persistent presence of energies that confound them from within" (2010, 23). This seems an excellent definition of the raw energy of early musique concrète, though it is certainly not the baroque Schaeffer talked of towards the end of his life, which steps backwards into the future: "It will be when our contemporary researchers… realise that there's no way out of traditional music, that we can get down to a baroque music for the 21st century" (Schaeffer and Hodgkinson 1987).

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